

Figure 9.34 (Continued)

9.5.7 Phulkari

Region

Phulkari is an embroidery style that is originated in Punjab. The earliest possible article of phulkari embroidery is a rumal embroidered during15th century by Bibi Nanaki, sister of guru Nanak dev. The needlework is widely practiced by the women of Punjab. It carries significance in the life of a woman, from her marriage until her final abode to heaven.

Technique

The base material to execute Phulkari is handspun and handwoven Khaddar that is dyed in red, rust, brown, blue and darker shades. Soft untwisted silk thread 'Pat' is used for the embroidery. The colours of the thread are red, green, golden yellow, orange, blue etc. The basic stitch employed for Phulkari is a darning stitch, which is done from the wrong side of the fabric. The stitches follow the weave and a beautiful effect is created on the fabric by changing the direction of the stitches. For outlining of motifs and borders, stem, chain and herringbone stitches are used.

Motifs

The motifs used in Phulkari are inspired by objects of everyday use like rolling pin, sword, flowers, vegetables, birds, animals etc. They are generally geometrical and stylized. Usually, one motif is left unembroidered or is embroidered. This motif is called 'nazarbuti' which is considered to ward off the evil eye.

Style of Embroidery

The two embroidery styles prevalent in Punjab are Bagh and Phulkari. Bagh is a fully embroidered wrap that is used for special occasions whereas Phulkari is simple and lightly embroidered for everyday use

End Use

Phulkari is an essential part of the bridal clothes and is worn as a veil or wrap by women on special occasions. A specific pattern of Phulkari is also used as the canopy on religious occasions. Presently, Phulkari is being done on bed linen and apparel like tops, tunics, and skirts.



Figure 9.35 Phulkari Embroidery

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